

Getting Started

Everything you need to bring, install, and set up before Week 1. This is the standalone requirements and setup guide.

What you need

Bring these to the course. Everything listed is free.

A laptop	Windows 10 or 11, or a Mac (macOS). You need to be able to install software on it. Chromebooks and iPads will not work for this course.
Internet	A reliable connection. Copilot and GitHub both run online.
A GitHub account	Free. You will create one in Step 1 below.
GitHub Copilot access	Free for students through GitHub Education. Set up in Step 2.
Two free tools	The GitHub Copilot CLI and Git. Installed in Steps 3 and 5.
No experience	You do not need any coding or terminal experience. We teach the basics you need.

Start early

Student verification for Copilot can take 1 to 2 days. Do Steps 1 and 2 as soon as you can, not the night before class.

Setup steps

Do these before your first class session, in order.

Step 1: Create a GitHub account

1. Go to github.com/signup (<https://github.com/signup>)
2. Sign up with your email (a personal email is fine)
3. Choose a username you're happy with, since it'll become part of your website URL
(`yourusername.github.io`)
4. Verify your email

Already have a GitHub account? Skip to Step 2.

Step 2: Get GitHub Copilot free access

GitHub Copilot is free for students through GitHub Education.

1. Go to education.github.com/benefits (<https://education.github.com/benefits>)
2. Click "Get student benefits"
3. You'll need to verify you're a student (school email, student ID photo, or enrollment letter)
4. Approval usually takes a few minutes but can take up to a few days

Step 3: Install the GitHub Copilot CLI

This is the tool you'll use to build everything in this course. Pick the command for your computer.

Windows:

1. Open Terminal (search "Terminal" in the Start menu)
2. Run: `winget install GitHub.Copilot`
3. Close and reopen Terminal when it finishes

Mac:

1. Open Terminal (press `Cmd+Space`, type "Terminal", press Enter)
2. Run: `curl -fsSL https://gh.io/copilot-install | bash`

3. Close and reopen Terminal when it finishes

Where's my terminal?

Windows:

Search "Terminal" in the Start menu.

Mac:

Press Cmd+Space and type "Terminal".

On older Windows 10 machines you may not see "Terminal." Search "PowerShell" instead, or install "Windows Terminal" free from the Microsoft Store. Any of these works the same for this course.

Step 4: Launch and sign in

1. Start the Copilot CLI by typing: `copilot`
2. On first launch, type `/login` and press Enter
3. Follow the prompts to sign in with your GitHub account (it opens a browser)
4. Once signed in, you're ready to go!

Step 5: Install Git

Git tracks your code and is what the Copilot CLI uses behind the scenes to deploy your apps.

1. Go to git-scm.com/downloads (<https://git-scm.com/downloads>)
2. Download and install for your system, keeping the default options
3. **Mac:** You may already have it. Run `git --version` in Terminal to check
4. Verify: run `git --version` and you should see a version number

Verify everything works

Open your terminal and run `copilot` . Once it starts, type a simple request:

```
Say hello and tell me a programming joke
```

If Copilot responds, you're all set!

Checklist:

- ☐ GitHub account created and email verified
- ☐ GitHub Education benefits applied
- ☐ Typing `copilot` launches the tool
- ☐ You signed in with `/login` and got a response to a test message
- ☐ `git --version` shows a version number

Troubleshooting

- **"copilot is not recognized"**: Close and reopen your terminal after installing. On Windows, you may need to restart your computer.
- **"winget is not recognized" (Windows)**: Update to the latest Windows, or install "App Installer" from the Microsoft Store, then try again.
- **"Copilot access denied"**: Make sure you ran `/login` and your Copilot access is active (check at github.com/settings/copilot).
- **Education verification pending**: You can still use the free Copilot tier while you wait. Everything in this course works with it.
- **Stuck?**: Bring your laptop to class 10 minutes early. We'll get you sorted.

Never used a terminal?

No problem. You only need a few commands for the whole course: `mkdir` (make a folder), `cd` (move into a folder), and `copilot` (start Copilot). The `~` symbol is a shortcut for your home folder.

Work through the Terminal Basics reference card (<https://michaeljolley.github.io/ccs-coop/reference/terminal-basics.html>) before class and practice moving around with `cd`. It fits on one page.

Reference materials

Keep these open while you build. They're the quick-reference companions to the lessons.

Terminal Basics (<https://michaeljolley.github.io/ccs-coop/reference/terminal-basics.html>)

Prompting Cheat Sheet (<https://michaeljolley.github.io/ccs-coop/reference/prompting-cheat-sheet.html>)

Glossary (<https://michaeljolley.github.io/ccs-coop/reference/glossary.html>)